



Vote of trust

Clean electoral rolls are a must, but must not be weaponised by state

President Donald Trump's appreciation of India's election mechanism has put the spotlight on a highly divisive debate over election integrity in the two democracies. Mr. Trump is pushing for an SIR-like exercise in the U.S., but its highly federalised electoral process is governed by fragmented rules and politics that resist the idea. His curious social media post citing India's Chief Election Commissioner, Gyanesh Kumar, as having wondered how the U.S. could conduct elections without a valid photo identity, has renewed concerns over election integrity in both the U.S. and India. While no one can disagree that the process should be fair and transparent, the agreement ends there. Partisan politics in both countries have fostered political mistrust, leading election losers to repeatedly question electoral integrity. The liberal and progressive strands, and the conservative and nativist strands in both countries, want to purify and streamline the electoral rolls and the processes, but in different and often contradictory ways. India and the U.S. could lead a shared democratic agenda on election rules, but only after restoring trust and integrity in their electoral processes.

India's nationalised election administration system has largely worked well, though it now faces a crisis of legitimacy. The U.S.'s decentralised system leaves too many loopholes in the process of enrolment and voting, and it could benefit from a more robust national framework like the ECI's. The expanded Safeguard American Voter Eligibility (SAVE) Act was passed in February and is pending in the Senate. The Constitution grants each State its own methods: "...but Congress may at any time by law make or alter such regulations", unlike the Indian Constitution, which establishes the ECI as a constitutional body. Though there is no ambiguity in existing law either in the U.S. or in India that only citizens may register and vote, the process of ensuring this has become hugely controversial in both countries. The proposed federal law would require proof of citizenship for voter registration and photo ID for voting. In India, the SIR is trying to sneak in this requirement without transparency, adequate consultation or sufficient time. The very fact that SIR is meant to be conducted only once in 20 years means it should be carried out carefully and inclusively. While ruling dispensations in both countries think that the election process is too permissive and allows foreigners to obtain voting rights, their opponents point to systematic and premeditated efforts to target social groups in the name of election integrity. What is needed is an acceptance that clean electoral rolls of citizens, and voting with photo ID, are elementary requirements of a fair process. In both countries, the state must not selectively weaponise these requirements against those not in power.

Due diligence

Curbs on surrogate advertising must avoid regulatory overreach

Maharashtra Food and Drug Administration (FDA) Commissioner Tukaram Mundhe's attempts to disrupt the marketing chain, by targeting the celebrities who prop up the brand recall of manufacturers' products, is an encouraging counterpoise to the consumer goods advertising landscape of today. This landscape has long suffered the consequences of a gross asymmetry: the person with the persuasive power suffers almost none of the economic downsides of consuming certain goods, a situation sustained as much by uncritical endorsement as by inequities in the public health-care system. But the FDA must still prove its suspicions. According to it, Vimal Elaichi – which Shah Rukh Khan, Ajay Devgn and Tiger Shroff have endorsed – does not have a market identity independent of its association with tobacco and that endorsing it amounts to a surrogate endorsement of tobacco products. While this seems a reasonable reading of the Cigarettes and Other Tobacco Products Act (COTPA) Rules, the Delhi High Court, in *DGHS vs Som Pan Product Pvt. Ltd.* (2024), had held that the state had a responsibility to prove a case of surrogate advertising. That is, neither could brand registration alone prove surrogate advertising nor could the mere existence of a technically legal product permit a particular advertisement.

While Mr. Mundhe's efforts are commendable, the FDA should follow through with inquiries under COTPA and the Food Safety and Standards Act 2006 that withstand scrutiny. India bears the world's largest burden of oral cancer, and the FDA is right to treat certain advertisements as unfair trade practices with significant consequences for consumer health. The endorser liability created by the Consumer Protection Act 2019, together with hefty financial penalties, has also undermined celebrities' ability to invoke ignorance of a manufacturer's intentions as a defence. The FDA's decision to have celebrity endorsers explain their decision-making is a logical extension of this principle in the domain of enforcement. The problem exemplified by tobacco also extends to products making unsubstantiated claims (e.g., "boosts immunity"), and educational and financial products. Unfortunately, India's regulatory regime is fragmented across a slew of Acts and Rules; problematic advertisements often invoke legal and administrative instruments to draw the judiciary's intervention. Penalties or bans in the FDA's case could significantly narrow the space exploited for surrogate advertising. If the FDA fails to act fairly, however, it could become yet another example of regulatory overreach that strengthened the practices it sought to end.

There is one, and only one solution to the decades long, volatile and bloody situation in West Asia: the creation or the establishment of a sovereign, independent, viable Palestinian state. In essence, it is no different from the oft-touted two-state solution. But the two-state formula speaks of the establishment of two states living side by side in good neighbourliness. However, one state already exists. What is needed is to establish or create a new, second state, namely Palestine. There will never be peace and stability in the region unless this is done. All the conflicts in the region – Israel's war on Gaza, the Iran war, the Hezbollah-Israel war, the Houthi phenomenon – will not be resolved unless a viable Palestinian state comes into being. Israel's relations with its Arab neighbours will remain strained until it accepts the reality of a Palestinian state, just as the Arabs have reconciled to the reality of Israel.

United States President Donald Trump seems to have recognised the importance of working towards the creation of a Palestinian state. Resolution 2803 setting up a Board of Peace (BoP), which was adopted by the United Nations Security Council in November 2025 has the following provision in its annex: "While Gaza re-development advances and when the PA [Palestinian Authority] reform program is faithfully carried out, the conditions may finally be in place for a credible pathway to Palestinian self-determination and statehood, which we recognize as the aspiration of the Palestinian people."

On Iran and Israel

A major player in this conflict-infested region is Iran. Iran has not always been hostile to Israel. Indeed, under the Shah, Iran's relations with Israel were cordial and there was a sizeable Jewish community in Iran. Since the Islamic revolution of 1979, most Jews left for Israel. But there are still about 15,000 Jews in Iran. Iran's Constitution provides for a seat for the Jewish community in Parliament.

Historically, there has not been perpetual enmity between Islam and Judaism. The Koran mentions many prophets and patriarchs from the Hebrew bible, such as Moses, and Abraham. The Crusades were fought between Muslims and Christians; the Jews were not a party to them. Jews were persecuted in countries professing Christianity. The Arabs bore no responsibility for the Holocaust which was carried out by Nazi Germany and its collaborators. It would not be an



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The road to peace in West Asia runs through Palestinian statehood

exaggeration to say that but for the Holocaust, and the sense of guilt felt by the western countries, Israel might not have been born. It is well known that most western countries, including the U.S., barred the entry of Jews seeking refuge from Hitler's Germany.

The transition from holy land to homeland started with the infamous Balfour Declaration of 1917 when the British expressed support for a homeland for the Jews, expressly limiting the indigenous Arab population only to civil and religious rights.

The roots of regional hostility

The hostility of Iran and the Arab countries towards Israel is based on the fact that Israel was created and imposed on the region at the expense of the indigenous Arab population. It is argued that the Palestinians were offered a state in the UN resolution of 1947 and a few times subsequently, but they rejected all offers. An Israeli Foreign Minister, Abba Eban, famously said that the Arabs never miss an opportunity to miss an opportunity. But one can hardly blame a landlord if he rejects an offer of a few rooms from an intruder who has occupied the whole house. Indeed, the slogan of the Zionists was: land without people for a people without land

It is noteworthy that Hezbollah, a Shia movement, and Iran, a Shia-majority country, support Hamas, a Sunni movement. This is easily explained by their commitment to the right of self-determination for the Palestinian people. Israel naturally comes in for hostility as the only power that stands in the way of the emergence of an independent Palestine.

Hezbollah began launching rockets and missiles against Israel just after Israel started its war on Gaza after October 7, 2023. It follows that if Israel accepts the reality of a Palestinian state at some time, Hezbollah will have no reason to make the life of people in northern Israel difficult.

In that case, Iran too will stop supplying weapons to Hezbollah. This is not to suggest that if the Palestinians are able to exercise their right of self-determination, Iran and Israel will become friends. But without that, their mutual enmity will never abate. If an irreversible road map to a Palestinian state emerges and is accepted by all the parties, secondary issues such as the Strait of Hormuz will be much easier to resolve.

Since Hamas' terrorist attack on Israeli civilians in October 2023, whatever little support some in Israel had for the concept of a Palestinian state has evaporated. Israel's disproportionate and

ruthless strikes on Gaza, post October 7, might have almost isolated Israel, but in the process, the Gaza strip has been devastated and the possibility of the emergence of Palestine has receded by many years, perhaps decades. Consequently, peace and stability in the region have become an illusion.

Mediation is the key

The only way to have a realistic possibility of resolving the conflict is through external mediation. And the only external power that has the required influence and even goodwill with both sides is the United States. It is true that there is no such thing as an honest broker. But brokers, even non-honest ones, do manage to sell the transaction to the satisfaction, or equal non-satisfaction, of both parties.

Israel has insisted on bilateral talks, adding at the same time that there is no one on the other side to negotiate with. Usually, the stronger side insists on a bilateral approach, and the weaker side prefers an outside agency to help. The only time progress was achieved was when the Oslo Accord was concluded in 1993. Oslo was negotiated with the mediation or good offices of Norway.

Under Oslo, the Palestine Liberation Organization formally recognised Israel and the PA was created; it is this PA, albeit a reformed one, that is often mentioned as a possible caretaker government of Palestine. The Oslo Accords paved the way for Jordan's recognition of Israel and eventually the Abraham Accords.

The other viable broker is the UN. Israel at the moment is dead set against the UN and has even declared the UN Secretary-General *persona non grata*. But Israel owes its existence to the UN. There is nothing permanent in international relations. Positions evolve with evolving situations.

Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu has his own personal reasons for opposing the idea of an independent Palestine. He had voted against the Oslo Accords and is implacably opposed to the idea of a Palestine state.

Let us hope that in due course, enlightened leadership will emerge in West Asia on all sides. If the leaders do not have the wisdom and the courage to make the necessary decisions, however difficult, the people of the region will remain doomed to suffer and be denied the peace and stability they need. Without these, they will never be able to realise the full potential for development that new technologies have to offer.

Before new taxes, making every rupee count

Every Budget season in Tamil Nadu produces the same refrain: the State needs more money, the Centre owes the State more, and taxpayers must prepare for new levies. The first Budget of the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) begins with a different question: Before asking citizens for another rupee, has the State collected every rupee legally due to it – and spent what it has as well as it should?

The data, the facts

Tamil Nadu's fiscal position is genuinely difficult. Debt is high, the revenue account remains in deficit, and salaries, pensions, welfare and interest payments leave limited room to manoeuvre. None of that is in dispute. What is in dispute is whether the response should begin with new taxation, or with making the State's existing revenue collection and expenditure substantially more efficient.

The Comptroller and Auditor General of India's (CAG) own numbers make the case. In 2023-24, Tamil Nadu budgeted about ₹4.47 lakh crore and spent roughly ₹4.14 lakh crore – a net underspend of ₹33,302.53 crore. Separately, ₹1,078 crore in supplementary provisions across 81 cases in 26 grants was found to be unnecessary because the original allocations had not even been exhausted.

The same audit records that 2.89% of revenue expenditure and 6.14% of revenue receipts had not been reconciled with the Accountant General's own records. None of this is proof of corruption. It is evidence that budgeting and accounting systems can be considerably more disciplined.

This is the argument for zero-based budgeting: an allocation should not continue automatically because it appeared in last year's Budget; it should justify its continuation and its amount. This writer has seen the idea take shape



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Before Tamil Nadu asks for more, it must collect better and spend smarter

first-hand in the United States, where Jimmy Carter used zero-based budgeting as Governor of Georgia and later introduced it into the federal budget process as President. Tamil Nadu adopted the same principle on paper in 1988, the very year Carter's own experiment had long since faded from Washington. It never became the governing discipline of the Budget here. Paired with performance-based budgeting – not how many crores were released for road works, but how many kilometres were built, at what cost, and to what standard – it stops to be an accounting exercise and becomes a management tool.

Data-driven governance standards

Numbers discipline government only when they are measurable and comparable. As a starting point, the TVK government should work toward department-wise performance data alongside comparable figures from other States and, where available, the Union government – cost per kilometre of road, cost per household connected to piped water, administrative cost per welfare rupee delivered. It can begin where data is most readily available and expand as systems improve, rather than promise a complete comparison on day one.

There is already a live example of what competition does to cost. When the Greater Chennai Corporation opened smaller road-restoration contracts to wider bidding, a ₹25 lakh Ambattur project drew nine contractors and closed 25.9% below the official estimate. That is not proof that the whole system was previously running 25% over cost – a lower bid still has to deliver the same specifications, and one tender cycle is not a trend. But it is a working demonstration that transparent competition can create real fiscal value without a single new tax. The same logic applies to revenue. A separate

CAG audit flagged ₹1,538.18 crore in irregularities across 337 Goods and Services Tax (GST) cases, of which only ₹8.64 crore had been recovered at the time of audit, alongside 244 taxpayers operating outside the GST net altogether.

These are audit findings requiring verification and due process, not revenue the government can book today. But they point to an obvious principle: before raising rates on people who are already paying honestly, exhaust the scope for improving compliance and collection efficiency. This is the brief given to the Montek Singh Ahluwalia-led Revenue Augmentation Committee – not simply to look for new taxes, but to close compliance gaps, rationalise exemptions, and identify revenue that the State is currently failing to collect.

Spending to outcomes

The same discipline has to apply on the spending side. The government has announced a high-level Expenditure Reforms Committee to review schemes for their impact and ensure that resources reach intended beneficiaries without restricting genuine welfare expansion. This is where performance-based budgeting becomes critical. The question is not merely how much was allocated or spent, but what that expenditure produced: how many kilometres of road were built, how many households received reliable drinking water, how many students gained measurable educational outcomes, and how many beneficiaries actually received the intended support.

This is not an argument for less welfare. It is an argument for welfare that can be measured.

Fix the leaks first. Spend against outcomes, not habit. Then decide what, if anything, still needs to be asked of the taxpayer. That is the standard that the TVK will hold this Budget to – and the standard it intends to hold itself to.

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Guard against overreach

Students constitute the intellectual vanguard of a nation and have an inalienable right to articulate their grievances through peaceful and democratic means. The indiscriminate registration of criminal cases against genuine protesters can have deleterious repercussions on their academic pursuits, professional prospects, and psychological well-being. The Supreme Court of India's intervention is a salutary reminder that the majesty of the law must coexist with freedom of expression and the democratic right to dissent

(Front page, "Ready to drop FIRs against student protesters, says SC", August 19). Justice must be administered with impartiality, restraint, and compassion so that the future of innocent students is not imperilled by unwarranted criminal proceedings. **Nagarajamani M.V.**, Hyderabad

Issue with centralisation

The National Testing Agency (NTA)'s decision to hold re-examinations in three subjects confirms the agency's continuing callousness. India has enough talent, but what it

lacks is the will to strive for perfection. It has been proved beyond doubt that the NTA cannot improve, making it imperative to find a viable and meaningful alternative. The obsession with centralising everything, including entrance examinations, has proved meaningless and wasteful. The better course would be to leave education and health care to the States, providing funds wherever necessary. States such as Tamil Nadu and Kerala achieved great heights when these two sectors were under the States' purview. Now, instead of other States catching up

with them, poor quality is being universalised. A policy change is therefore imminent. **A.G. Rajmohan**, Anantapur, Andhra Pradesh

Black money and polls

The Supreme Court of India hit the nail on the head when it observed that black money in the electoral process compromises democracy, the rule of law and the electoral process itself (Inside pages, August 18). The Election Commission of India must ensure free and fair elections, for which political parties and citizens must cooperate. One feels that

Generation Z, which took the nation by storm through its recent protests against the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) fiasco and succeeded, can take up this serious issue as well. **S. Ramakrishnasayee**, Chennai

Faulty roll revision

The government and the Election Commission of India may have the backing of the Supreme Court to clean voter lists of duplicate, fake and non-existent voters. But who authorised them to declare a living voter 'permanently shifted or dead'? My spouse

submitted her Special Intensive Revision form online, as the Booth Level Officer never visited, and received an acknowledgement. Yet, in Telangana's recently released draft electoral roll, her name is missing. On checking further, we found it listed under "Permanently Shifted/Dead". How can a living voter be declared dead or permanently shifted without verification or even a visit to her residence? **N. Nagarajan**, Secunderabad

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